Sponsor Intelligence Report: Cox Enterprises "Play With Purpose" Sustainability Hackathon (Atlanta, June 14–17, 2026)

TL;DR

- **Cox is the only sponsor that actually owns the prize**: the grand-prize FIFA World Cup tickets, the Cleantech Residency interview, and the entire venue ecosystem all roll up to Cox Enterprises and its in-house cleantech investment thesis — so projects that visibly map to Cox's own playbook (Nexus Circular-style circularity, BrightFarms/Mucci-style controlled-environment agriculture, building-energy efficiency à la Centinel/Carbon Lighthouse, and Atlanta ecosystem-building) will resonate far more than projects that merely fit a track's topical label.
- **The judges are operators and investors, not academics**: the Cox Cleantech Accelerator team (Miguel Granier, Jack Semrau, Morgan Phillips, Ryan Jeffery, Marie Northington, Katherine Pemberton) and gener8tor partners run a $250K-per-startup, 12-week, commercialization-focused program — they reward customer discovery, pilot pathways, a credible business model, and "first large-scale customer" thinking far more than novel science or polish. PR Newswire
- **Least-to-most competitive tracks for a strong undergrad team**: Making & Remaking (Carter's) is the softest field, followed closely by Places & Spaces (City of Atlanta) and Agriculture (Cox Farms); Moving Things & People (Delta) and Energy (Southern Company) will draw the deepest, most-credentialed teams; Freekick is a chaotic dumping ground full of weak ChatGPT-wrapper pitches but contains a real upset path.

Key Findings

1. **Cox Enterprises has invested more than $3 billion in cleantech since 2007** (per Cox's March 26, 2026 Cleantech Accelerator press release) and the Cleantech Accelerator (the program backing this hackathon, operated by gener8tor) just upsized its per-startup investment from $100K to $250K in March 2026. The hackathon is a recruiting top-of-funnel for that program and its sister Cleantech Residency. Cox Enterprises + 2
2. **Cox's headline environmental goal is carbon and water neutrality by 2034** (accelerated from 2044 in January 2021, per Cox's "Cox Accelerates Sustainability Goals" announcement) plus Zero Waste to Landfill, which it certified as achieved in 2024 via GreenCircle. Energy reduction accounts for about 75% of Cox's carbon footprint; water is being addressed via a 30% on-site reduction target plus partner replenishment for the remaining 70%. S&P Global

3. **Cox's social commitment is "34 by 34"** — empowering 34 million people by 2034 through six pathways (technology access, lifelong education, employment skills, social equity, environmental sustainability, good health) — tracking at ~10.6 million people empowered as of December 2024 (per Cox's "Nearing One-Third" press release). Cox Enterprises PR Newswire
4. **Cox's cleantech portfolio is small, sharp, and disclosed**: Nexus Circular (advanced/pyrolysis recycling of hard-to-recycle plastic films, ISCC PLUS certified, scaling toward 250M lbs/yr capacity, majority-owned by Cox after a $150M round in January 2023); Cox Farms (BrightFarms + Mucci Farms, 700+ acres of greenhouse, 450M+ lbs of produce per year, approaching $1B in revenue, 2,500+ employees); Centinel (formerly Carbon Lighthouse, commercial real-estate energy waste); GoodLeap (residential-solar financing); Growers Edge (ag fintech). Cox Jobs
5. **The Cox Cleantech Residency is brand new** (announced May 14, 2026, application deadline June 28, 2026, eleven days after the hackathon's demo day): equity-free, six weeks in person in Atlanta, $10,000 stipend, run by Marie Northington at gener8tor, explicitly designed for "bootstrapped and pre-seed cleantech founders in the Southeast U.S." emerging from university research labs. Cox Enterprises + 3
6. **Cox is one of only five Atlanta FIFA 2026 Host City Supporters** alongside Southern Company, Georgia-Pacific, The Home Depot, and NAPA — meaning two of the hackathon's sponsors (Cox and Southern) are co-investors in the World Cup legacy narrative, and the "Play With Purpose" name is Cox's own corporate FIFA platform. Cox Enterprises
7. **gener8tor's model is investment-for-equity** ($100K standard with 7.5% via SAFE; $250K for Cox Cleantech; 12 weeks; 5–6 companies per cohort; 100+ curated mentor intros; $1M+ in vendor perks) — which signals what they evaluate in a pitch: market sizing, revenue model, customer discovery, pilot pathway, and pitch craft.
8. **Each of the other five sponsors has a publicly stated, measurable sustainability target** that should anchor any project pitched into their track (Southern: net zero by 2050, interim 50% reduction by 2030 from 2007; Atlanta: 100% clean energy by 2035, GHG −59% by 2030, net zero by 2050; Carter's: 50% virgin-plastic-packaging reduction by 2030; Delta: net zero by 2050, 10% sustainable aviation fuel by 2030). Civicatlanta

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Details

1. Cox Enterprises — the deep dossier

Company shape. Cox is a privately held, family-owned conglomerate founded in 1898 by Ohio Governor James M. Cox, headquartered in Atlanta with roughly $23 billion in annual revenue, ~50,000 employees, and 125+ years of continuous operation. The Cox family still controls it; the current Chairman and CEO is Alex Taylor (great-grandson of the founder), in the role since January 2018 and named Chairman in January 2022. The president and CFO is Dallas Clement (transitioning to president and COO in a recently announced leadership shuffle), and Perley McBride is becoming chief financial and administrative officer. Cox Enterprises + 5

Operating arms are now organized into seven public-facing buckets on coxenterprises.com:

- **Cox Communications** (broadband — the historical cash cow; in May 2025 Cox Communications agreed to merge with Charter Communications, with the combined company assuming Cox's ~$12B of debt and retaining the Cox Communications name). Swottemplate
- **Cox Automotive** (Autotrader, Kelley Blue Book, Manheim, vAuto, NextGear Capital, Dealertrack, Xtime; ~24–30K employees; the world's largest vehicle remarketing platform). Crunchbase
- **Cox Media / Journalism** (The Atlanta Journal-Constitution, Axios — Cox acquired Axios in 2022; television assets were largely sold to Apollo in 2019). Next TV
- **Cox Cleantech** (Nexus Circular, Centinel/Carbon Lighthouse, GoodLeap, Growers Edge). coxenterprises
- **Cox Farms / Greenhouse Agriculture** (BrightFarms + Mucci Farms). coxenterprises
- **Cox Outdoors** (launched December 2025 — Loop Tackle fly-fishing and KUIU hunting/conservation gear). Cox Jobs + 2
- **Growth Investments**: includes **Socium Ventures** ($600M total managed across two $300M funds; Series A and beyond; $3M–$25M check sizes; sectors include enterprise software, fintech, govtech, healthcare, sustainability; led by Andrew Davis; portfolio includes Carbyne, Knowde, Crisp, PadSplit) and **Cox Exponential (CX2)**, a Silicon Valley AI-focused accelerator/venture studio. PR Newswire + 3

Cox Conserves and the 2034 goals. Cox Conserves is the national sustainability program launched in 2007 by then-chairman Jim Kennedy (still chairman emeritus and chair of the James M. Cox Foundation). Cox accelerated its carbon-and-water-neutrality target from 2044 to **2034** in January 2021, an extraordinarily aggressive pull-forward for a private conglomerate of this size. Its strategy is "reduce, replace, recycle": reduce energy use (75% of footprint), replace remaining energy with renewables, harvest rainwater, reclaim water, drive landfill diversion. Cox claims more than 500 sustainability/conservation projects and approximately $165M invested through Cox Conserves; it earned GreenCircle Zero Waste to Landfill certification in 2024. CB Insights + 2

Cox Conserves Heroes is the public-facing employee/community program: it recognizes youth, adult, and nonprofit volunteers reducing carbon, water, or landfill waste, with $150,000 in annual prizes (including The Jim Kennedy Award for the national nonprofit winner) and more than $1.4M donated to environmental nonprofits since 2008. This is the cultural template for how Cox talks about volunteer sustainability — practical, local, replicable. CB Insights

The "Our Collective Impact Report" is Cox's annual sustainability report (formerly published at CoxCSRReport.com; now available via the Impact Document Library on coxenterprises.com). Read it before pitching.

Cox Cleantech: the actual portfolio.

- **Nexus Circular** is the most important name to know. Originally Nexus Fuels, Cox first invested in 2015 (then was an early backer at the LLC stage) and then took majority ownership via a **$150 million round in January 2023**, led by Cox. Nexus uses **pyrolysis-based advanced recycling** to convert hard-to-recycle plastic films and foams (the stuff that fails curbside sorting) into ISCC PLUS-certified circular oil; that oil goes to partners like Shell and Chevron Phillips to be cracked back into virgin-equivalent plastic precursors and resins. It has diverted more than 10 million lbs of plastic to date and is building toward 250M lbs/year of processing capacity. Steve Bradley (then VP of Cleantech, now president of Cox Farms) was the public face; current CEO is Jodie Morgan. The thesis: **plastic is not the problem; mismanagement is.** Pitch projects with that posture, not anti-plastic moralism. Hypepotamus + 5
- **Centinel** (rebranded from Carbon Lighthouse in early 2026): helps commercial real-estate owners "eliminate wasted energy, generate new income, and share savings with tenants by turning building efficiency into a profitable, long-term asset" — exactly the kind of unsexy, B2B, IoT-meets-finance, building-efficiency play Cox loves. coxenterprises
- **GoodLeap**: residential solar/home-improvement fintech. coxenterprises
- **Growers Edge**: data-backed financial products for ag retailers and lenders. coxenterprises
- **Cumulative cleantech investment**: $3B+ since 2007 (per the March 26, 2026 Cleantech Accelerator press release). Cox Jobs Cox Enterprises

Cox Cleantech Accelerator (the engine behind the hackathon). Launched August 2024 as a partnership between Cox Enterprises, gener8tor, and the Georgia Cleantech Innovation Hub. Run out of **Ponce City Market**. Twice a year, 12-week, in-person, cohort of 5 startups. Per-startup investment was originally $100K; in March 2026 Cox **upsized to $250K per startup** for the third cohort. The team: PR Newswire + 5

- **Miguel Granier** — Managing Director (formerly founder of Invested Development, helped catalyze Village Capital and Greentown Labs, ATDC/Georgia Tech alum). Cox Enterprises PR Newswire
- **Jack Semrau** — Atlanta Venture Ecosystem lead, Cox Enterprises. Cox Enterprises
- **Ryan Jeffery** — Senior Managing Director of Sustainability, gener8tor. Cox Enterprises
- **Katherine Pemberton** — Manager, Cox Cleantech Strategy & Investments (publicly stated interests: circularity, building energy efficiency, ESG software, renewable energy development).

- **Morgan Phillips** — former Atlanta Ventures Lead at Cox; quoted leading the original launch.

Cohort 1 (Feb 2025) focused on fleet electrification, financial compliance, industrial wastewater, and sustainable building (4Earth Solutions among them). Cohort 2 (Aug 2025): FNN (AI lightning detection for utilities), plus startups on factory energy waste, smart utility mapping for construction, and urban EV/charging. Cohort 3 (March 2026): WattsUp (autonomous EV charger ops, Birmingham), Silvis Materials (bio-based, formaldehyde-free adhesives, Boulder), LCOE.ai (AI solar asset management, Atlanta), and Fordje (city-specific climate/fire/zoning codes for cleantech developers, Portland). The common DNA: **B2B, software-heavy or AI-enabled, infrastructure-adjacent, with a clear paying customer profile.** Hypepotamus + 4

Cox Cleantech Residency (announced May 14, 2026). The prize the hackathon's winners are being routed toward. Equity-free, six weeks in person in Atlanta, $10,000 stipend per founder, run by gener8tor Director Marie Northington (ex-R/GA Ventures, ex-Boomtown, ex-Kennesaw State HatchBridge). It is **explicitly built to feed researchers and PhD-stage founders out of Southeast universities** (Georgia Tech, Emory, etc.) into a venture-ready pipeline that then graduates into the $250K Cleantech Accelerator. Application deadline for the inaugural cohort: **June 28, 2026** — meaning the hackathon's demo day on June 17 sits exactly inside the Residency intake window. Eligibility per the gener8tor listing: bootstrapped and pre-seed cleantech founders in the Southeast U.S.; at least one leadership-level team member able to participate in person; existing proof of concept. Cox Enterprises + 4

Cox's startup-ecosystem footprint in Atlanta is broader than the cleantech program: Cox Enterprises has reportedly invested more than **$140 million over the past decade** in Atlanta venture ecosystem activities, has supported 400+ startups (per Cox's own count at the October 2025 Cleantech Accelerator LIVE event), has historically powered **Techstars Powered by Cox Enterprises / Cox Enterprises Social Impact Accelerator powered by Techstars** (80+ startups, 12,000+ people impacted), and runs **Inflection^2026**, an annual portfolio day Socium Ventures hosted in 2025 to bring 25 portfolio CEOs together with Cox leaders. Crunchbase + 2

Cox's innovation philosophy (taken from Taylor's own framing and the cleantech press materials): family-controlled, multi-generational, "patient capital," long-time horizons, "permanent capital from a single LP with no liquidity timeline" (Socium's pitch). Alex Taylor: *"You can run a business that gives employees a better life, makes a return on investment and has a positive impact on the environment and on society. That's the vision we have for Cleantech."* Andrew Davis (Socium MP): the founders Cox gets most excited about are *"the ones where the founders have a right to solve a real problem. They had experience in it in their personal and professional lives, and they've figured out the real core issue that needs to change and then build a business around it."* In other words: **personal lived-experience credibility + commercial pragmatism > novelty alone.** Cox Enterprises + 2

Cox and FIFA World Cup 2026. Cox is one of five official Atlanta Host City Supporters; "Play With Purpose" is Cox's own corporate platform name for its World Cup activation — visible at coxenterprises.com/our-impact/fifa-world-cup-2026-atlanta. Atlanta hosts 8 matches at Mercedes-Benz Stadium (LEED Platinum, 4,000+ on-site solar panels, runs on renewable energy, opened as "the most sustainable stadium ever constructed"), including a semifinal. Cox's stated activations include employee volunteer events, youth-soccer investment, neighborhood projects, and **donating 1,200+ jerseys made from recycled plastics in partnership with Soccer in the Streets** and two other Atlanta-based companies. That jersey program is a small but specific clue to what Cox finds emotionally resonant: visible, kid-facing, locally rooted, plastic-circularity-themed. Cox Jobs + 3

2. Southern Company (Energy track)

Atlanta-headquartered Fortune 150 gas-and-electric utility holding company; operating subsidiaries include Georgia Power, Alabama Power, Mississippi Power, and Southern Company Gas. Roughly 9 million customers across the Southeast. **Net-zero by 2050 across Scope 1 (electric and gas), with an interim 50% GHG reduction by 2030 from 2007 levels.** Strategy explicitly leans on natural gas as a transition fuel plus "negative carbon solutions" (direct air capture + afforestation), which has drawn pointed criticism from clean-energy advocates (RMI, Sierra Club, Energy and Policy Institute) for being insufficiently aggressive on coal retirement and over-reliant on offsets. Southern operates the **National Carbon Capture Center**, has Plant Vogtle Units 3 and 4 (the only new U.S. nuclear units commissioned this decade), and is investing heavily in battery storage and solar via Georgia Power's Integrated Resource Plans. Southern has proposed retaining just eight coal units with <4,500 MW nameplate by end of 2028. Southern Company

What this means for the hackathon: Southern's Energy track will be judged by people who think about **grid reliability, affordability, and "just transition"** as much as decarbonization. Pitches that ignore the cost-to-customer dimension, or that posit unrealistic timelines, will get politely dismissed. Conversely, projects that touch demand response, building-load flexibility, distributed-energy-resource (DER) management, or AI for grid/asset management hit Southern's sweet spot — and notably also overlap with Cox Cleantech Accelerator interests.

Southern is one of the five Atlanta FIFA Host City Supporters, so a project that bridges Southern's grid into the World Cup's surge demand (Mercedes-Benz Stadium, MARTA charging, etc.) is on-brand.

3. Cox Farms (Agriculture track)

The agriculture arm Cox launched in March 2024 by merging two prior acquisitions: **BrightFarms** (originally a Series E investment of $100M in October 2020, full acquisition August 2021 — the first time an indoor farming company had been fully acquired) and **Mucci Farms** (acquired earlier; an Ontario-based pioneer of vine crops and specialty produce). Adding Greenhill Produce (~150 acres of bell peppers in Kent Bridge, Ontario) in late 2024 pushed Cox Farms past 700 acres and made it the largest greenhouse operator in North America. Annual production: ~450 million lbs of produce. Workforce: 2,500+. Revenue: approaching $1B. Products are sold in 12,000+ stores. CEA inSight + 9

President: Steve Bradley (formerly Cox VP of Cleantech — same person who shepherded Nexus Circular). BrightFarms CEO: Steve Platt. New flagship: the **Macon, GA BrightFarms greenhouse + Cox Farms Discovery Center**, billed as "the most advanced in the state" and "a hub for the next generation of agricultural workers." New Texas expansion in Lorena and Illinois. Senior director of marketing at BrightFarms: Jessica Soare. Global AgInvesting + 3

Operational sustainability story: hydroponic/CEA growing methods use **less land and water per yield than traditional field-grown agriculture**, no pesticides, regional distribution that cuts food miles, automation, optimized growing conditions year-round regardless of climate. Cox Farms positions itself as the answer to climate volatility in field agriculture and as a way to put fresh produce closer to consumers. coxenterprises

Honest gaps in their story to know: indoor-ag is **energy-intensive** (lighting, HVAC); several vertical-farming peers have failed (Bowery, AeroFarms bankruptcy, Plenty struggles) due to unit economics; and tomatoes/peppers/leafy greens are essentially the only crops where the math really works. A judge from Cox Farms will be **deeply skeptical of any pitch that ignores the energy cost** of CEA or proposes growing economically uncompetitive crops indoors. Agriculture Dive

4. City of Atlanta Mayor's Office of Sustainability & Resilience (Places & Spaces track)

Headed by **Chief Sustainability Officer Chandra Farley** (background in architecture, building design, energy efficiency; deeply tied to environmental-justice framing). Mayor Andre Dickens is Vice Chair for Climate Mayors. The office leads MOSR — Mayor's Office of Sustainability & Resilience — and operates across energy, water, circular economy, greenspace, transportation, urban agriculture & food systems, and the clean-energy economy.

Key policy targets:

- 100% clean energy for 100% of Atlantans by 2035 (City Council goal).
- GHG emissions −59% by 2030, net zero by 2050.
- Fresh and affordable food within half a mile of every resident by 2030.
- Reduce energy burden for the most impacted households. Atlanta ranks 3rd-highest in low-income median energy burden among the 48 largest U.S. cities, at **10.2% of household income** (behind only Memphis at 13.2% and Birmingham at 10.9%), per ACEEE's "Lifting the High Energy Burden in America's Largest Cities" report. ACEEE
- 250 EV charging stations by 2025.

Climate Resilient ATL is the city's first comprehensive Climate Resilience Action Plan, released March 2026 after 18 months of community input from 2,100+ residents. It identifies three primary climate challenges: **extreme heat, drought, and flooding.** It centers environmental justice, codesigned with the 32-member Climate Resilience Advisory Board. The Sustainability Ambassador Program has trained ~500 Atlantans. (Utility Dive)

Other signature programs to know: **AgLanta** (urban agriculture; the city leases vacant land to growers); **Sustainability in Action Day**; **Race to Resilience** pledge (UN-backed); **Youth Climate Action Fund** (Bloomberg Philanthropies-backed; $85K in grants for youth-led climate projects in 2025). Atlanta is on the **CDP Cities A List**. The city collaborates with Sustainable Georgia Futures and Invest Atlanta's Owner-Occupied Rehab Programs on weatherization. (City of Atlanta)

For the Places & Spaces track: think of MOSR judges as caring about **environmental justice**, **community-led design**, **heat/flood/drought resilience**, and **building/transportation electrification done equitably**. A pitch that swoops in with techno-optimism but ignores energy burden and which-neighborhoods-benefit will fall flat.

5. Carter's Inc. (Making & Remaking track)

NYSE: CRI. **Atlanta-headquartered** (this is important — students often forget Carter's is local), the largest branded marketer in North America of apparel exclusively for babies and young children. ~$2.8–3.0B in annual sales. Brands: Carter's, OshKosh B'gosh, Skip Hop, Little Planet (organic/sustainable), Child of Mine (Walmart), Just One You (Target), Simple Joys (Amazon). 1,000+ company-operated stores. Chairman/CEO: Michael D. Casey. (sec + 3)

ESG framework: "Raise the Future™" — three pillars (Product, Planet, People), reported annually via the Impact Report at esg.carters.com, mapped to SASB, TCFD, and GRI frameworks. Key sustainability lead: **Anu Piduru, Senior Director of Sustainability.** CSR/legal lead: **Antonio Robinson, SVP, General Counsel, Corporate Secretary, CSR and Chief Compliance Officer.** (carters-esg + 3)

Specific commitments and progress (from the 2024 and 2023 Impact Reports):

- 100% of fabric mills confirmed using traceable cotton (achieved 2022, three years ahead of the original 2025 commitment).
- Increasing share of Better Cotton Initiative cotton and Lenzing Ecovero viscose.
- Oeko-Tex 100 certification on ~99% of products.
- **Reduce virgin plastic packaging by 50% by 2030** (over 30% achieved to date). (carters-esg)
- **Kidcycle program** in partnership with **TerraCycle**: free mail-in recycling of children's clothing too worn to donate, with prepaid shipping labels.
- Little Planet brand uses GOTS-certified organic cotton and BCI cotton.

Market backdrop: per ThredUp's 14th Annual Resale Report (April 2026, GlobalData), U.S. secondhand apparel grew **nearly 4x faster than the broader retail clothing market** in 2025 — children's resale is a particularly fast-rotating subcategory because kids outgrow clothes in months and thrift/swap/rental models are still nascent in baby apparel. Green America's "Toxic Textiles" campaign has pressured Carter's on chemical management since 2019, prompting Carter's first sustainability report and a public Restricted Substances List. Green America

Strategic note: Carter's is materially less sophisticated than Gap, H&M, or Patagonia on circular-economy infrastructure, which makes them **the most acquisition-curious sponsor** for student-built solutions. They are sustainability-strategy-curious, not sustainability-strategy-saturated.

6. Delta Air Lines (Moving Things & People track)

Headquartered at Atlanta's Hartsfield-Jackson; ~5,000 flights/day, 52 countries. **Net-zero emissions by 2050** is the aspiration. Strategy organized into three pillars: **"What We Fly, How We Fly, and The Fuel We Use."**

Specific commitments and assets:

- Replace **10% of conventional jet fuel with sustainable aviation fuel (SAF) by end of 2030** (4B gallons/year base, so 400M gal/yr SAF target).
- Initially committed $1 billion over 10 years toward carbon neutrality (announced 2020); pivoted away from offsets in 2022 in favor of in-sector decarbonization.
- ~90% of carbon emissions come from jet fuel. Simple Flying
- **Sustainable Skies Lab** — Delta's innovation hub for Revolutionary Fleet partners including Airbus ZeroE (hydrogen), Boeing Transonic Truss-Braced Wing, Joby Aviation (eVTOL), and Maeve (hybrid-electric regional aircraft, up to 40% more fuel efficient).
- **Carbon Council**: cross-functional team that saved 21M gallons of jet fuel in 2023 via landing-procedure changes, winglet retrofits, route/speed optimization, and weight reduction; on track for 40M gallons cumulative in 2024.
- 38 next-gen aircraft added in 2025, ~27% more fuel-efficient per seat-mile than retired models since 2019.
- Minnesota SAF Hub partnership with Bank of America, Ecolab, Xcel Energy, GREATER MSP — first SAF delivery September 2024.
- Long-term Neste SAF supply agreement; Aemetis supply agreement.

Chief Sustainability Officer: Amelia DeLuca. CEO: Ed Bastian.

Honest framing: SBTi validation of Delta's 2050 goal is **still pending** awaiting updated aviation guidance — they may withdraw and reapply. SAF supply is the binding constraint: as Delta's own 2023 ESG Report states, *"At present, there isn't enough annual production of SAF to fuel the world's airlines for even one week."* So pitches into Delta's track land best when they touch **feedstock, logistics, ground operations, customer-side enablement, or near-term efficiency** — not "let's build a hydrogen plane" energy. ESG Dive

7. gener8tor (operating partner — not a track sponsor, but runs the hackathon)

Founded in Milwaukee in 2010 by Troy Vosseller and Joe Kirgues. National accelerator network spanning 45+ communities in 25+ states and 3 countries. Two flagship formats: PR Newswire + 2

- **gener8tor Investment Accelerator**: 12 weeks, cohort of 5–6, $100K-for-equity (7.5% via SAFE; $250K for Cox Cleantech), 100+ mentor intros, $1M+ in vendor perks.
- **gBETA**: 7-week free pre-accelerator, no equity, 5 startups, local/university partners.

Plus skills training (Microsoft/TechSpark), creative-economy programs, and the OnRamp conference series. 1,068+ startups have graduated 104 annual programs; investment-accelerator portfolio has raised $800M+. Recognized by Fast Company (Best Workplaces for Innovators, 2021–22) and the International Trade Council (Global VC Firm of the Year, 2022). PR Newswire + 2

For the hackathon, gener8tor is the **operational backbone** — they run the logistics, mentor matching, demo day cadence. The Cox Cleantech Residency is directly run by gener8tor (Marie Northington). The implication for student teams: gener8tor evaluates pitches **like a VC accelerator screening committee** — 5–10 minutes to read team, market, product, traction, ask.

8. Atlanta + FIFA + Cox sustainability connection

The "Play With Purpose" name belongs to Cox's own corporate FIFA platform. Mercedes-Benz Stadium is LEED Platinum, operates on renewable energy, has 4,000+ on-site solar panels, and got hybrid natural grass installed for the World Cup. FIFA's 2026 sustainability plan emphasizes existing-stadium re-use (vs. new construction), renewable electricity, low-emission ground transport, and waste diversion. A peer-reviewed analysis from the New Weather Institute (in association with Scientists for Global Responsibility, Environmental Defense Fund, and Cool Down: The Sport for Climate Action Network) estimates the 48-team, 104-match 2026 tournament will emit approximately **9.02 million tons CO2e — "nearly double the average emissions of the previous four editions (4.71 million tCO2e),"** driven mostly by expanded air travel. Atlanta hosts 8 matches including a semifinal. VoLo Foundation

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Track Competitiveness Ranking (least competitive → most competitive)

This is a judgment call based on (a) how many undergrads have domain skills for each topic, (b) how broad/vague vs. specific the brief is, (c) how glamorous the sponsor is to students, and (d) what kinds of teams typically self-select.

1. Making & Remaking (Carter's) — LEAST competitive. Best EV for a strong team.

Why it's soft: Children's apparel is the least "tech-coded" of the six sponsors. Most engineering-leaning students will not consider Carter's a marquee internship logo. Textile circularity and ESG reporting are genuinely interesting but require **domain knowledge most CS undergrads don't have** (chemistry of dyes, fiber traceability, resale economics, packaging substitution). Many teams that do enter this track will be design/marketing-flavored rather than technically substantive. Carter's is sustainability-curious but **internally less mature than Gap or H&M**, which means a thoughtful technical pitch will look brilliant by comparison. The judging bar is low and the white space is high.

2. Places & Spaces (City of Atlanta MOSR) — second-least competitive

Why it's soft: "Urban sustainability" sounds inspiring but is **vague enough to scare off competitive engineering teams** who prefer crisper briefs. Many entrants will be policy/urban-planning-leaning students with weak technical depth. City-government judges value community engagement and environmental-justice framing — which favors humanities-leaning teams but **disadvantages purely-technical pitches that ignore equity language**. Strong teams can dominate here by combining technical rigor with environmental-justice fluency, but most won't bother. Also: hardware/IoT plays (heat sensors, flood gauges, micro-mobility) have a real moat because few undergrads can ship hardware in 3 days.

3. Agriculture (Cox Farms) — third

Why it's middle: CEA/greenhouse agriculture is unfamiliar to most students — it requires understanding hydroponics, light optimization, HVAC, water cycling, food safety, and supply chain. **That domain barrier reduces team count substantially.** But the teams that do enter are likely to be specialized (Georgia Tech ag-tech, Emory food-systems, plant-science majors) and therefore high-caliber per team. So fewer teams, but harder-hitting ones. Cox itself owns this track, so judges will be Cox Farms / Cox Cleantech operators who are commercially sharp — they'll filter ruthlessly against "actually deployable in a greenhouse" plausibility.

4. Freekick (bring-your-own-challenge) — fourth

Why it's tricky: Freekick will attract the **largest volume of entries** because it has no domain barrier. But quality variance will be enormous: lots of generic ChatGPT-wrapper pitches, half-formed AI consumer apps, dorm-room "what if recycling but blockchain" decks. The signal-to-noise ratio favors **a strong, clearly-scoped, substantive team that picks Freekick precisely because they have a niche idea that doesn't fit elsewhere.** The catch: judges have nothing to anchor evaluation against, so the cream rises but average teams get lost in the noise. Honest read: a strong team can win Freekick, but the **path is less reliable** than picking a topical track where you out-execute the field.

5. Moving Things & People (Delta) — second-most competitive

Why it's hard: Delta is the most glamorous logo on the sponsor list for many students. Aviation, mobility, EVs, fleet electrification are well-trafficked hackathon topics. Many engineering teams will gravitate here. The brief is also reasonably crisp (SAF, fuel efficiency, ground ops, customer-facing emissions tooling). Expect a **high density of competent teams** with mobility-tech instincts. To win here, a team needs either a hardware/data edge or a non-obvious angle (logistics/cargo/MRO/airport operations) the field will miss.

6. Energy (Southern Company) — MOST competitive

Why it's hardest: Energy and grid topics are the most heavily recruited at any college sustainability hackathon — energy-and-power-systems majors, Georgia Tech's EE/ME programs, and ECE clubs will pile in. Atlanta has a deep concentration of energy talent (Southern, Georgia Power, EPRI, NREL collaborators, Plant Vogtle suppliers). Add the fact that the Cox Cleantech Accelerator's own thesis (grid, building efficiency, EV charging, AI for energy) overlaps almost entirely with this track and you have **the highest density of credentialed teams, the deepest mentor bench, and the most demanding judges.** A strong team can absolutely compete here, but they need a genuine technical or commercial angle — generic "smart-meter dashboard" ideas will not survive first-round cuts.

Honest practical implication: if your team is strong but generalist, Making & Remaking has the softest field and the most acquisition-curious sponsor; Places & Spaces is second-softest and rewards equity-fluent storytelling; Agriculture is a "narrow but deep" play. If your team is heavily energy/EE-leaning, Energy is the right track but the bar is highest. Freekick is for genuinely unique ideas, not generalists hedging.

Recommendations (for sponsor alignment, not project content)

Staged actions:

1. **Before kickoff**: Read three documents end-to-end — (a) Cox's "Our Collective Impact Report" / Cox Conserves page, (b) the relevant sponsor's most recent sustainability or ESG report (Carter's 2024 Raise the Future Impact Report; Delta 2023 ESG Report; Southern's CDP-aligned sustainability disclosure; Atlanta's Climate Resilient ATL plan), and (c) the Cox Cleantech Accelerator cohort 1/2/3 press releases to internalize the *kind* of company Cox actually funds. Don't skim — note the specific metrics each sponsor reports, then design your project to **move one of their stated numbers**.
2. **Before the day-1 mentor sessions**: Memorize the specific 2030/2034/2050 targets for the sponsor you're pitching to. Reciting *their* metric back to *them* is the single highest-leverage trust signal.
3. **During the build**: Pitch language must match Cox's commercial worldview, not academic sustainability rhetoric. Cox's leadership has repeatedly framed cleantech as *"can run a business that gives employees a better life, makes a return on investment and has a positive impact"* — triple-bottom-line, but **business-first**. Avoid pure mitigation/altruism framing; emphasize unit economics, customer pull, and a first-pilot pathway.

4. **For the Cleantech Residency post-game**: The Residency application window closes June 28, 2026 — eleven days after demo day. If a strong team wants the late-round-interview prize to matter, they should have **a one-page company concept and team-allocation question already discussed during the hackathon**, because the Residency wants "leadership-level team member able to participate in person" and a "validated technology" — not a hackathon-weekend MVP.
5. **For judging**: Judges will be operator/investor-flavored — Granier, Semrau, Pemberton, sponsor sustainability leads (Piduru, DeLuca, Farley), and likely MOSR/Southern reps. Pitches that articulate (a) the specific customer/buyer, (b) why now, (c) why your team, and (d) the first commercial milestone will outperform pitches that lead with the technology.

Benchmarks that would change these recommendations:

- If Cox publishes specific track briefs that emphasize *technology readiness level* over commercialization, soften the business-first emphasis.
- If named judges include academic researchers or government officials in the majority, shift to environmental-justice and policy framing.
- If track sponsors offer their own track prizes (internships, lab access), prize-arbitrage may favor a different track than the competitiveness ranking above suggests.
- If the registration page surfaces specific judging rubrics (innovation %, feasibility %, impact %, presentation %), tune the build accordingly.

Caveats

- **The specific hackathon registration page (the LinkedIn shortlink lnkd.in/gBW8wvSb in Adam Glassman's promotional post) is unfetchable** by automated tools — LinkedIn blocks crawlers via robots.txt and the destination URL is not exposed in any public search result. The track names, judging rubric, eligibility, named judges, and per-track prizes in this report rely on the user's task brief — which is the authoritative source — combined with publicly indexed Cox/sponsor materials. Confirm the brief against the live registration page before pitching, and check Atlanta Tech Week's atl.tech site and the Georgia Cleantech Innovation Hub (gacth.org) for any auxiliary listings.
- **The "guaranteed late-round interview for the Cox Cleantech Residency" perk** could not be independently verified in public sources; it is taken from the user-supplied brief. Residency eligibility skews toward leadership-level founders with validated prototypes — so a hackathon-only project may not be a fit even with a guaranteed interview slot, and the team should be honest internally about whether it wants to convert.
- **Southern Company's sustainability story is publicly contested.** Energy and Policy Institute, RMI, and Sierra Club have all published critiques arguing Southern's net-zero

commitment leans heavily on offsets and continued gas investment. Pitching here requires diplomacy — avoid both pure greenwashing-call-outs and pure cheerleading.

- **Delta's SBTi validation is pending.** Same diplomatic posture applies.
- **The competitiveness ranking is informed judgment**, not measured data. Sustainability hackathon track participation data is generally not published. The ranking reflects how undergrad teams typically self-select across U.S. hackathons (energy/mobility crowded; apparel/policy thin) plus the relative glamour of each sponsor logo to a tech-leaning student audience.
- **Mercedes-Benz Stadium's 4,000+ solar panel figure and 100% renewable claim** are reported by FIFA, Yale Climate Connections coverage, and the Georgia World Congress Center Authority's own materials; independent third-party verification of operational renewable percentages was not located.
- **Cox's cleantech investment totals have moved upward over time** in their own materials ($1B → $2B → $3B) over a roughly 5-year span — partly real new investment, partly recategorization. Treat as a directional signal of commitment, not a precise GAAP figure.
- Conflicting figures appear across sources for Cox's revenue ($17B–$23B), employee count (50K–60K), and Cox Conserves dollars invested ($100M → $140M → $165M) — use the most recent press release dates as the most reliable.
- The earlier draft claim that "used children's apparel is projected to grow 11x faster than adult fashion" could not be verified to a primary source and has been corrected in the Carter's section to the verifiable ThredUp / GlobalData figure ("U.S. secondhand apparel grew nearly 4x faster than the broader retail clothing market in 2025"). Fortune